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Sun Microsystems' Net usability guru, Dr Jakob Nielsen, calls the Internet a procrastination apparatus. We agree, and perhaps can even add a corollary—it also teaches us to always find the easy way out, more so when it comes to research.

The World Wide Web is both an information treasure house, and a well-laid trap.

Reliable, credible research comes at a premium, and finding the right place on the Web can be tricky. Professional research sites, hence, assume even more impor-

and specific research sites make more sense.

For instance, vivisimo.com, a metasearch site that aggregates content from various search sites and collates them in order of relevance. Researchers across the world swear by it, and it was rated second, only to Google, in a survey by about.com, conducted in May 2004. Let's focus on research sites, however, and look at six sites covering different professional fields:

IT Papers

www.itpapers.com

Arguably one of the largest online libraries for technical white papers, Web casts, and case studies. Itpa-

site, though, and at \$7 (Rs 330) a page of 225 words, it seems expensive. But, if you want to download large documents, it would cost you \$133 (Rs 6,250). This site is reasonably priced if you want large documents that can be accessed via e-mail, by fax, by courier, or by postal mail.

Go beyond Google

For a cost that is astonishingly low, you can get the best research available to you at your fingertips. Here's how

tance—they are credible and can be quoted in your internal research papers, presentations, forecasts for market growth, etc.

Since they are created by independent industry experts, the research is reliable. Academics, too, publish journals that are posted regularly on the Web.

One research site that is not an academic enterprise is about.com, which has information neatly categorised, and each category and its topics are lead by experts in a specific field—all of whom are carefully chosen through a strict screening procedure. Unfortunately, for most of us, searching for anything on the Web, starts and ends at Google.

But Google, for its versatility and immense intelligence, has its limitations (see box: *Five Reasons Why Google Doesn't Always Work*).

Perhaps metasearches

pers offers free membership, and lets you access downloads, detailed descriptions, and personalisation features. You can also request for white papers from this directory, and contact vendors directly as well. Information technology topics include data management, hardware, Internet, networking and communications, software, security, platforms, OS, etc.

Academic Research

www.academicresearchpapers.com

Its simple interface deceives you—don't let it! The site's zero-scroll home page has 76 primary topics of research, and gives access to thousands of research papers and documents in categories ranging from Asian Studies to Architecture; from Astronomy to History. This is a paid

